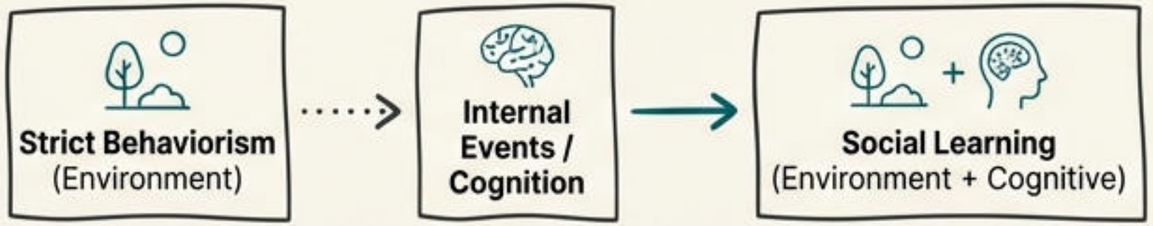
Bandura's Social Learning Theory

A Shift Toward Mentalism

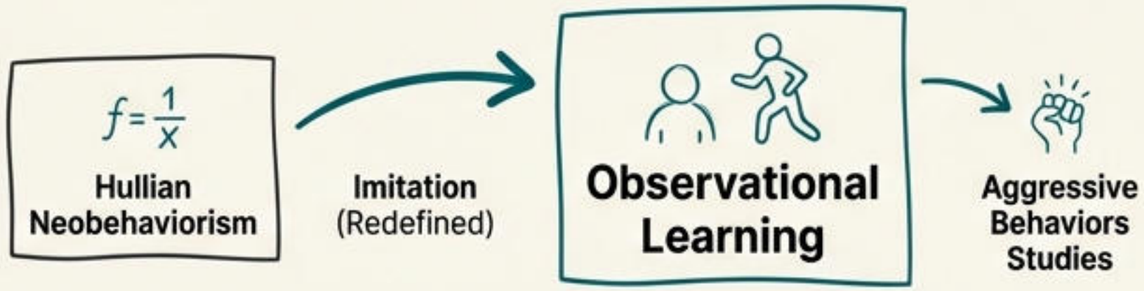
Albert Bandura's social learning theory represents a significant step toward incorporating cognitive concepts into behaviorism, moving beyond the stricter environmental focus of earlier schools. While Tolman's work hinted at a return to mentalism, Bandura's approach is a more explicit and robust integration of internal events.



Roots in Neobehaviorism

The theory's origins can be traced to Hull's neobehaviorism, as Bandura was exposed to Hullian theorists during his graduate training. The very term "social learning theory" was first coined by Hull's followers who were applying Hullian principles to human social behavior, with a specific focus on the process of imitation.

Bandura's primary interest was in imitation, which he redefined and expanded as **observational learning**. He became the leading researcher in this field, with his most renowned studies examining the powerful influence of observational learning on the acquisition of aggressive behaviors.



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Conceptual Alignment with Tolman

While influenced by Hullian concepts, Bandura's interpretation of the learning process aligns more closely with Tolman's purposive behaviorism. This alignment is evident in several key areas:

- **Molar Approach:** Like Tolman, Bandura focuses on broad, holistic behavior patterns rather than discrete, molecular stimulus-response links.
- **Learning vs. Performance:** He emphasizes the critical distinction between what an individual has learned and what they choose to perform. Learning can occur vicariously, without any change in overt behavior, until incentives are present.

The Central Role of Internal Events

Bandura diverges from Tolman in the status he accords to internal events. For Bandura, concepts like expectations are not merely theoretical conveniences; they are **actual, influential events** occurring within an individual that actively shape their behavior. Furthermore, he introduces a uniquely human cognitive element: **self-referent thoughts**. These are thoughts about our own abilities, accomplishments, and potential, which Bandura argues have a profound and direct impact on our actions. This perspective validates the use of introspectively observed, subjective experience as a legitimate source of data in explaining behavior.

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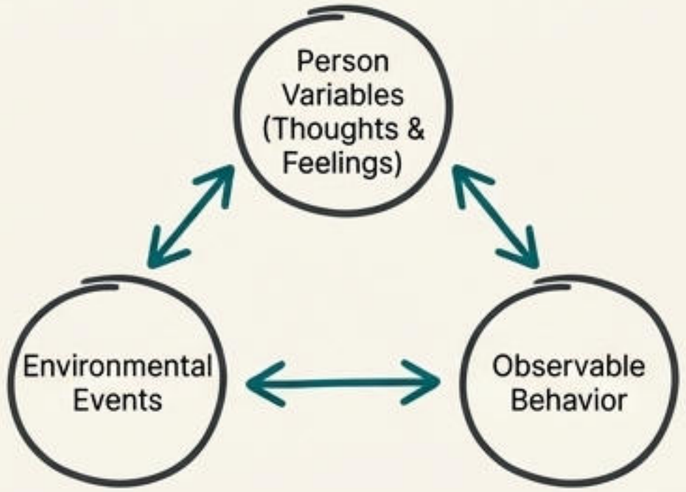
The Cognitive-Behavioral Approach

Bandura's framework is best understood as a cognitive-behavioral approach. It synthesizes the behaviorist focus on environmental influences and learning with a robust appreciation for the role of cognitive variables. He later relabeled his waled his theory "social-cognitive theory" to place even greater emphasis on these cognitive processes. The core of this approach is the idea that human functioning is explained by the interplay of observational learning and these internal cognitive factors.

Reciprocal Determinism: A Triadic Model

Bandura proposed a unique view of determinism called **reciprocal determinism**. This model stands in contrast to simpler, linear models where the environment influences internal events, which in turn cause behavior (Environment → Internal Events → Behavior). Instead, Bandura posits a three-way, dıteraction where environmental events, observable behavior, and "person variables" (including thoughts and feelings) all reciprocally influence one another.



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Reciprocal Determinism in Action: The Date Example

To understand this dynamic interplay, consider the following scenario:

1. **Environment → Behavior:** You are on a date with someone you find attractive (environmental event). To impress them, you tell a joke (observable behavior).
2. **Behavior → Environment:** Your joke is off-color and your date reacts with a look of horror (your behavior has changed the social environment).
3. **Environment → Person Variable:** The look of horror (environment) elicits strong feelings of anxiety (person variable: feeling).
4. **Person Variable → Behavior:** Your anxiety (feeling) causes you to stammer while speaking (observable behavior).
5. **Behavior → Person Variable:** Observing yourself stammer (behavior) leads you to conclude, "They must think I'm an idiot" (person variable: belief/thought).
6. **Person Variable → Environment (Perceived):** This new belief (person variable) causes you to interpret your date's subsequent polite smile as a sign of pity (your belief has altered your perception of the environment).

This cascading interaction demonstrates how environment, behavior, and personal cognitive/emotional factors are locked in a continuous, mutually influential cycle.

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Skinner’s Radical Behaviorism

A Return to Stricter Behaviorism

In direct contrast to the trend of incorporating mentalistic concepts, Burrhus Frederick Skinner argued for a return to a more rigorous form of behaviorism. His philosophy, known as **radical behaviorism**, re-emphasizes the profound influence of the environment on observable (overt) behavior. Crucially, **it rejects the use of internal events as explanations for behavior**. Instead, it reconceptualizes thoughts and feelings as behaviors in their own right—behaviors that themselves require explanation by referencing environmental factors.

The Status of Internal Events

Unlike Watson’s methodological behaviorism, which tended to ignore internal events, radical behaviorism does not reject their existence. Skinner fully acknowledged the reality of sensing, thinking, and feeling. However, he categorized them as **"covert" or "private" behaviors**, subject to the same fundamental laws of learning that govern “overt” or publicly observable behaviors. They are part of a behavioral analysis, but only as additional behaviors to be explained, not as autonomous causes of other behaviors.

- **Social Learning View:** A student studies *because she expects* a high mark.
- **Radical Behaviorist View:** Both the act of studying (overt) and the thought about the high mark (covert) are the result of a past history of reinforcement (e.g., doing well on exams after studying).

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Why Internal Events Fail as Explanations: Four Core Problems

Skinner was deeply skeptical of using internal states as causal explanations for behavior, citing several fundamental problems.

1. Unreliability of Verbal Reports

We lack direct access to the internal events of others and must rely on their verbal reports, which are often unreliable. Skinner argued this unreliability stems from how we learn to label our private experiences.

- **The Labeling Process:** Parents teach a child to label internal states by inferring them from observable behavior. To teach the word "pain," a parent observes a child crying after stubbing a toe and says, "That must hurt!" The label "hurt" becomes associated with the private sensation through this publicly mediated process.
- **Imprecision is Inevitable**: This process is inherently imprecise. For subtle emotions like "contentment" or "discomfort," the corresponding observable behaviors are far less distinct. The labels parents provide are crude approximations, meaning the way we learn to describe our feelings may not accurately reflect what we are actually experiencing.

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2. Ambiguous Causal Relationships

A second problem is the difficulty of determining the true temporal and causal relationship between thoughts, feelings, and actions. Consider the act of helping in an emergency. Which model is correct?

- ***(a) Feeling Precedes Behavior:*** An emergency occurs, you feel concern, and that feeling *causes* you to help. (Emergency → Feeling of Concern → Provide Help)
- ***(b) Feeling and Behavior are Parallel:*** The emergency triggers both the feeling of concern and the act of helping simultaneously, with no direct causal link between them. People often act quickly in emergencies without first introspecting on their feelings.
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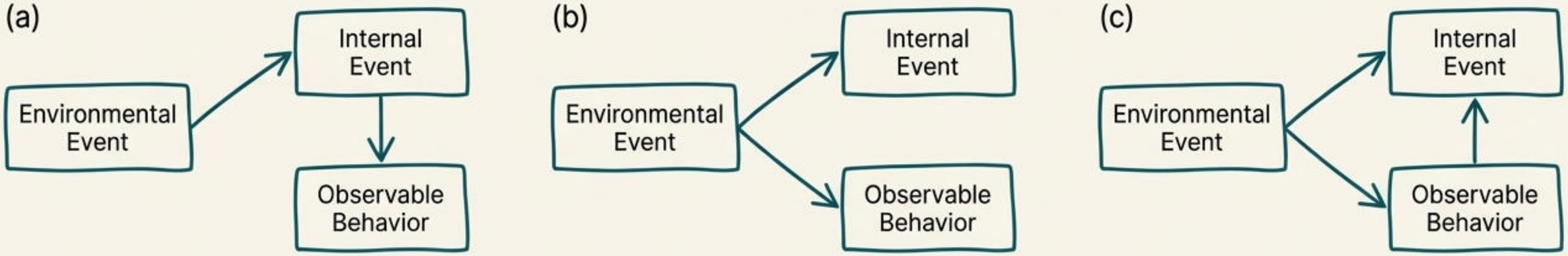
- ***(c) Behavior Precedes Feeling:*** The act of helping, once initiated, may actually *generate* or strengthen the feeling of concern. Research shows that engaging in a behavior (like writing a pro-capital punishment essay) can alter one's underlying feelings and opinions to be consistent with that behavior.



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3. Inability to Directly Intervene

A third, pragmatic difficulty is that we have no means of directly changing internal events. The only way to alter thoughts, feelings, and overt actions is by manipulating some aspect of the environment.

For example, a therapist might instruct a client to “think calm, relaxing thoughts” in an anxiety-provoking situation.

- A cognitive-behaviorist might attribute the reduced anxiety to the calming thoughts themselves.
- A radical behaviorist would argue that the effective treatment is not the thoughts, but the **therapist's instructions** about what to think.

Since providing instructions is a manipulation of the client's environment, it is ultimately an environmental change that is responsible for altering both the internal state (anxiety) and any related overt behavior. If the environment is the only viable point of intervention, then it should be emphasized as the ultimate cause of behavior.

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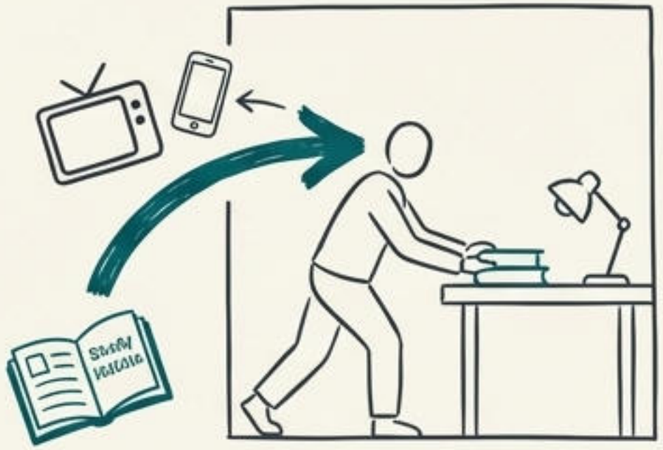
4. The Problem of Pseudo-Explanations

The final issue is that explanations based on internal states are often circular or non-explanatory pseudo-explanations. When a person says, “I feel like going to the movies,” are they describing an internal bodily condition, or are they simply making a prediction about their own future behavior? Often, such a statement simply means: ‘Under these circumstances, given my history, and if nothing prevents me, there is a high probability I will go to the movies.” To say, “I am going to the movies *because* I feel like going to the movies,” is tautological. The ‘feeling’ is not an explanation for the behavior; it is simply a verbal statement that correlates with the potential for that behavior to occur.

Countercontrol: Agency Through Environmental Engineering

Despite this emphasis on environmental determinism, Skinner did not view humans as helpless pawns. He introduced the concept of **countercontrol**: the deliberate manipulation of environmental events to alter their impact on our own behavior. For instance, a student who decides to rearrange her study environment for better focus is engaging in countercontrol. However, from Skinner's perspective, even this act is ultimately traceable to an environmental influence—perhaps she was exposed to information about the benefits of doing so. The environment remains the ultimate variable.



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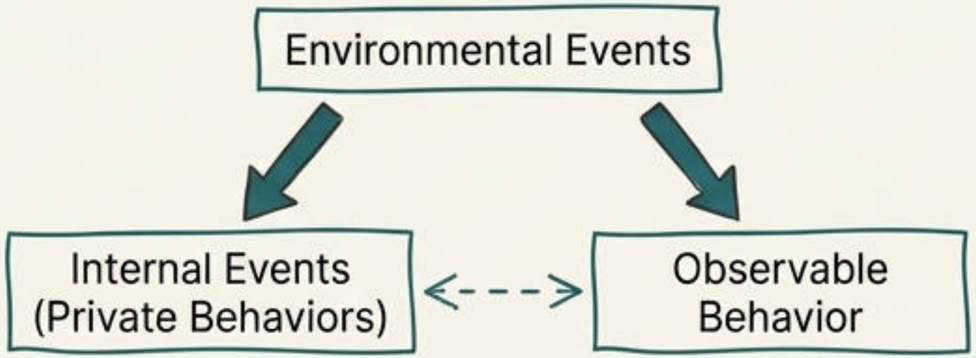
Skinner's View of Causality

Skinner might agree with Bandura that environmental events, internal events, and observable behavior interact. The critical difference lies in his insistence that the environment is the **ultimate determinant** of both overt and covert behavior. While reciprocal influences exist, the primary causal flow originates from the environment.



A Molar, Not Molecular, Perspective

It is a common misconception to label Skinner as a simplistic S-R psychologist. He agreed with Tolman in emphasizing a **molar** (holistic) rather than a molecular (chained S-R connections) view of behavior.

- **Reflexive Behaviors**: Automatically elicited by preceding stimuli (e.g., salivation). These fit an S-R model and can be classically conditioned.
- **Operant Behaviors**: Controlled by their consequences. These behaviors are more flexible, less predictable, and cannot be reduced to simple S-R chains.

The key difference in explaining a molar operant behavior like maze running:

- **Tolman**: The rat runs because it *expects* food. (Internal cognitive map)
- **Skinner**: The rat runs because, in its *past experience*, running has resulted in food. (History of reinforcement)

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The Role of Genetics & Evolution

Genes and Environment in Interaction

While behaviorists primarily study the effects of environmental experiences, this does not mean they discount heredity. Skinner, in particular, repeatedly acknowledged that behavior is fundamentally the result of a continuous **interaction between genes and the environment**.

Far from being dismissive of genetic factors, he was fascinated by research demonstrating genetic limitations on operant conditioning and even initiated early studies in this area. Ethology, the study of instinctive animal behavior, was seen as a complementary, not contradictory, field.

Operant Conditioning as 'Mini-Evolution'

Skinner noted a striking conceptual resemblance between operant conditioning and Darwin's principle of natural selection.

- **Natural Selection (Species Level):** Members of a species with adaptive inherited traits are more likely to survive and reproduce, increasing the frequency of those traits in the gene pool over generations.
- **Operant Conditioning (Individual Level):** Behaviors that lead to reinforcing consequences (i.e., are adaptive for the individual) are more likely to be repeated, increasing their frequency in that individual's behavioral repertoire. Behaviors that are non-adaptive (not reinforced) decrease in frequency.

Both are selectionist processes: Natural selection chooses adaptive genes, while operant conditioning chooses adaptive behaviors.

Natural Selection: Species

Natural Selection: Species

Selection over generations.

Operant Conditioning: Individual

Operant Conditioning: Individual

Reinforcement over time.

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The Optimism of Empiricism

While accepting the role of genetics, Skinner remained cautious about overemphasizing hereditary explanations for behavior, particularly for maladaptive patterns.

His reasoning was pragmatic and deeply humanistic:

- **Genetic explanations can foster pessimism.** If a behavior (e.g., a learning difficulty, aggression) is seen as hard-wired, there is a risk of assuming little can be done to change it.
- **Environmental explanations foster optimism.** An empiricist approach, which emphasizes the role of experience, implies that problems resulting from poor learning experiences can be corrected by providing better learning experiences.

This stance makes behaviorism an inherently optimistic philosophy regarding the potential for positive change. An empiricist teacher is more likely to believe a child's struggles in math can be fixed with better instruction, rather than being an unchangeable trait.

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Applied Behavior Analysis

From Philosophy to Science to Technology

1. **Radical Behaviorism (The Philosophy):** The set of core assumptions about the nature of behavior, the role of the environment, and the status of private events. This is the intellectual foundation.
2. **Behavior Analysis (The Science):** The scientific field that grew out of radical behaviorism, originally called the Experimental Analysis of Behavior. This science is dedicated to researching the basic principles of behavior, particularly operant conditioning.
3. **Applied Behavior Analysis (ABA) (The Technology)**: The application of the principles discovered by behavior analysis to solve real-world problems. Skinner was deeply committed to ensuring his science had practical utility.

The Impact of ABA

- **Clinical Disorders**: Treating phobias, schizophrenia, and other conditions.
- **Developmental Disabilities**: ABA is the treatment of choice for children with autism spectrum disorder.
- **Education**: Improving classroom management and instructional design.
- **Community & Global Issues**: Creating programs to encourage conservation, recycling, and public health initiatives.

While sometimes called behavior modification, ABA represents the direct and impactful legacy of Skinner's radical behaviorist philosophy.

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